

Chemical factory

The largest internal organ, the liver, is your body's chemical factory. It performs almost 500 different functions, including processing the nutrients released from food. It also makes the bile your digestive system uses to help break down fats.

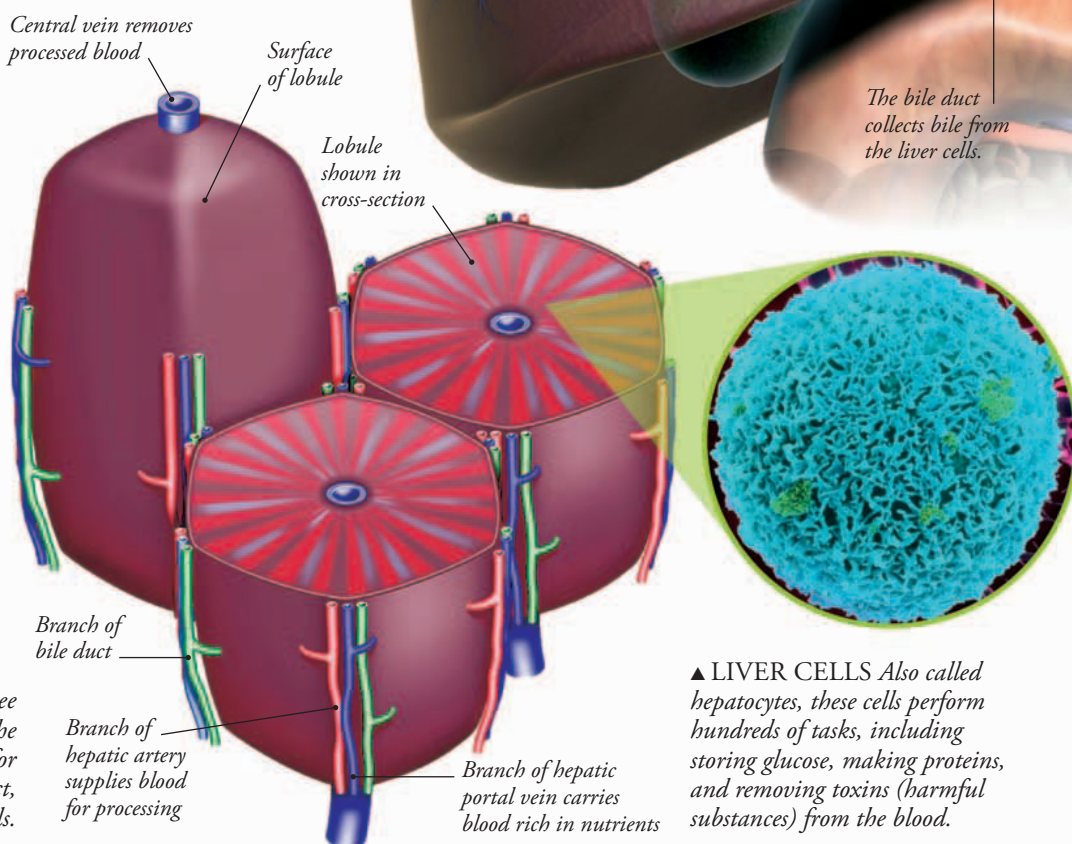
VITAL ORGAN

The liver is important because it processes, stores, and makes so many substances. For example, it stores and releases energy-rich glucose, processes fats and amino acids, stores vitamins and minerals, breaks down toxins and drugs, and recycles red blood cells. It also releases heat, helping to keep you warm.

LIVER LOBULES

The liver contains around one million sesame seed-sized processing plants called lobules. Inside a lobule, liver cells are arranged in plates that radiate out like spokes from a central vein. The cells filter substances out of the blood as it flows towards the vein and add other substances to it.

► **LOBULE STRUCTURE** Three vessels run along each corner of the lobules. Two supply blood for processing. The third, a bile duct, removes bile made by the liver cells.



▲ **LIVER CELLS** Also called hepatocytes, these cells perform hundreds of tasks, including storing glucose, making proteins, and removing toxins (harmful substances) from the blood.